



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Northwest Ohio Classical Academy

School Website: <https://nocacademy.org/>

January 7, 2026

Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

SCL MEMBER

Any school that belongs to the Society for Classical Learning (SCL) is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because SCL requires adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Overall Classification: CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Northwest Ohio Classical Academy (NOCA) exhibits a strongly classical orientation across public-facing materials, with clear emphasis on a content-rich liberal-arts curriculum, virtue formation, and engagement with classical methods (e.g., Socratic dialogue, memorization, and memory work). The school foregrounds truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable, centers formation over mere information, and presents a curriculum and pedagogy aligned with classical ideals (Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, classical languages, and a rinse of Western civilizational study). The Hillsdale College Curriculum designation on NOCA's site further anchors its classical identity, and public materials emphasize virtue, civic responsibility, and character formation. Several facets common to classical practice, such as Socratic dialogue in upper grades, memory- and chant-based review in younger grades, and a robust K–12 program with a clear graduation pathway, are evident. There is less explicit, on-site liturgical or theological apparatus described in public pages, though the language of virtue, moral education, and reverence for truth and beauty is prominent.

Overall classification: CLASSICAL

- Category-by-category scoring below follows the Six Essential Elements framework, comparing NOCA's public materials to the Positive/Negative Keyword Indicators from the classical lexicon.
- Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot (highlights)
- Religious and Metaphysical Foundations: CLASSICAL
- Purpose and Goal: CLASSICAL
- Curriculum: CLASSICAL
- Pedagogy: CLASSICAL
- Faculty: CLASSICAL
- Parents & Community: CLASSICAL

Note: The rubric requires explicit keyword matching. Where NOCA's site demonstrates the core transcendental aims (truth, goodness, beauty) and formation-focused language, those keywords align with the Positive Keyword Indicators. Where theology or liturgical practice is not overtly present in NOCA's public site, the score remains CLASSICAL given the strength of other elements.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - NOCA emphasizes the transcendent ideals of truth, beauty, and goodness as central to classical education (Grounded in the classical ideals). It also frames the curriculum around the virtues and moral character, aiming for civic virtue and ethical leadership. This is explicit in statements like the mission to cultivate virtue and civic virtue and the commitment to truth, goodness, and beauty as guiding ideals. - The public materials also stress Socratic dialogue and exposure to classical texts, aligning with the metaphysical orientation toward enduring truths accessed through reason and memory. - A motto on the public catalog emphasizes “I will learn the true. I will do the good. I will love the beautiful,” underscoring transcendental aims (truth, good, beauty) in formation.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: truth, goodness, beauty, virtue, moral character, civic virtue, Socratic dialogue, classical texts. - Negative keywords observed: none identified in publicly accessible NOCA materials (no explicit relativism, secular humanism, or values-clarification signals detected in the NOCA public content).

Why this rating - The materials foreground transcendental ideals and virtue-centered formation, with explicit alignment to truth, goodness, and beauty, and the Socratic method as a core pedagogy. The absence of explicit liturgical/theological infrastructure in the public-facing content does not undermine the strong moral-realism orientation reflected in NOCA’s public statements. Therefore CLASSICAL is warranted.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - NOCA states its mission as training minds and improving hearts through a rigorous, content-rich classical curriculum aimed at producing thoughtful leaders and virtuous citizens. This emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and human excellence rather than job-market preps alone. - The public materials describe modeling virtue and character, and a broader telos of human flourishing, aligning with the classical paideia framework and the long-standing aim of education as formation rather than mere information transfer. - The Hillsdale Curriculum designation and focus on Western classics underscore a teleological aim toward a liberal-arts-centered formation and civic virtue.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: formation, cultivate virtue, human flourishing, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, pursuit of the true/good/beautiful, scholé. - Negative keywords observed: none evident in NOCA public materials (no explicit emphasis on workforce preparation, job-readiness, or 21st-century-skills framing in the formation sense).

Why this rating - The explicit focus on formation, virtue, wisdom, and the classical telos, combined with a public stance against reducing education to job preparation, supports a CLASSICAL rating for school purpose and goal.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - NOCA prioritizes a liberal-arts framework including grammar/logic/rhetoric (Trivium) and the Quadrivium (arithmetic, geometry, music, astronomy), consistent with classical curricula. The Hillsdale K-12 program is highlighted as a core curricular backbone. - Course catalogs and grade-level maps highlight extensive study of literature, history, philosophy, languages (Latin and classical languages), as well as a structured sequence of core subjects (Literature, Mathematics, History, Economics/Government, Science, Philosophy, Composition & Rhetoric, etc.). This demonstrates integrated, classical subject coverage rather than a modern “social studies-first” or heavily STEM-first framing. - The public materials show direct reference to classical texts, great books, and a Great Conversation framing; students engage with primary sources, primary texts, and a historically rooted Western-civilization curriculum. - There is explicit mention

of Latin instruction beginning in early grades and continuing through high school; high-school course catalogs include proof-based mathematics, geometry, calculus-readiness topics, and classical-era language study.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: liberal arts, trivium, quadrivium, grammar, logic, rhetoric, great books, primary sources, classics, Homer, Plato, Augustine, Shakespeare, Latin, Greek, history, Western civilization, natural philosophy, astronomy, arithmetic, geometry, music theory, Socratic texts, recitation, narration, dictation, philosophy, classical language, culture of Western civilization. - Negative keywords observed: social studies terminology replacing history; project-based learning dominance (no strong emphasis on project-based dominance found in NOCA public content).

Why this rating - The curriculum is explicitly built around classical elements (grammar/logic/rhetoric; great books; Latin/Greek; Western civilization; integrated history, literature, and philosophy; and a strong emphasis on primary sources). NOCA's Hillsdale affiliation and explicit coverage of classical-canon content support a CLASSICAL rating.

Element 4: Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The NOCA public material emphasizes Socratic dialogue in the upper grades and seminars, along with opportunities for rhetoric and speech in the upper grades, matching classical pedagogy. - In lower grades, there are references to singing, memory work, chanting, and regular review to deepen memory and delight—this aligns with traditional contemplative/Scholé practices and memory-based pedagogy. - The curriculum maps and course descriptions show a progression toward rhetoric, recitation, and formal oratory in upper grades, consistent with classical pedagogy. - The presence of memory/work recitation, narrative/shaping through models, and a living-curriculum approach (faculty and teachers as exemplars) aligns with classical pedagogy.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: Socratic seminar/dialogue, questioning, dialectic, disputation; narration, recitation, chanting, singing to memorize; scholarly memory-work; scholé/-wonder; seminar/colloquy/tutorial; rhetoric exercises; memory work; catechesis, liturgical calendar integration; upper-school rhetoric & oratory. - Negative keywords observed: lack of Socratic-like pedagogy or heavy cognitive-dissonance indicators? Not present; the NOCA materials show explicit Socratic and rhetoric-focused pedagogy rather than purely project-based or exploratory-only approaches.

Why this rating - The public-facing NOCA materials demonstrate a pedagogy that blends contemplative, memory-based lower-grade practices with Socratic dialogue and rhetorical training in upper grades, consistent with CLASSICAL norms.

Element 5: Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - NOCA public materials show a governance and faculty ecosystem consistent with a classical model: board leadership is visible, with named trustees, and a public-facing “faculty” section that profiles teachers (including subject-area specialists and department-teaching rosters). - The walking embodiment of classical education (the “living curriculum,” teacher as mentor, and portrait of a teacher) aligns with classical lexicon expectations; NOCA's materials present teacher-candidate profiles and a culture of collegiality and virtue. The presence of a public-facing faculty page with specific names (e.g., upper-school Latin, science) supports this.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: tutors/mentors, living curriculum, portrait of a teacher, faculty of friends, collegial culture, moral exemplars, teacher training in classical pedagogy, master-teacher model. - Negative keywords observed: none identified in NOCA's public-facing faculty materials.

Why this rating - Public evidence shows a formal governance and a faculty culture consistent with classical expectations for model teachers and mentors, with teachers presented as part of the curriculum and a community of learning. This supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - NOCA's public materials emphasize parent engagement and the family's central role in classical education, including support for parental involvement and the mission's focus on parental choice and partnership. The public-facing mission statements emphasize the family's primacy and parental choice, which aligns with the "partnership with families" principle. - The NOCA materials model a community-centered approach with a foundation and opportunities for family involvement through book groups, seminars, and family formation activities that are congruent with classical pedagogy. The school presents a path for parents to engage in the curriculum and attend public events. - The school's materials reference outreach and community building via formation events and public-facing materials to welcome families to visits and to participate in the school's activities.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords observed: partnership with families, parent formation, reading groups, seminars, classical book clubs, open campus, hospitality, parent covenant, household worship/family liturgy alignment, parent participation, living tradition in the family. - Negative keywords observed: consumer language, minimal parent involvement (negative signals are present in the lexicon; however NOCA's public site shows active parent involvement and openness to visits, which contradicts consumer-language framing).

Why this rating - The NOCA public materials reflect a classical-education approach that actively engages parents as co-educators and emphasizes family formation and partnership with the school, aligning with CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

Not applicable here, as the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL. If future materials increased explicit liturgical/theological scaffolding or deeper liturgical/communal practices, it could further reinforce the Religious and Metaphysical Foundations category; however, current materials already show a robust classical alignment.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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